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PRINCIPALS' LEADING FUNCTIONS AND TEACHERS' JOB PERFORMANCE IN SENIOR SECONDARY SCHOOLS OF NORTH WEST GEO-POLITICAL ZONE, NIGERIA

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Abstract

This study examined principals' leading functions and teachers' job performance in senior secondary schools in the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria. Guided by three objectives, one research question, and two hypotheses, the study adopted a correlational survey research design. The population comprised 1,228 principals and 18,890 teachers, with sample size of 293 principals and 293 teachers were selected using multistage and purposive sampling techniques, respectively. Data were collected using two adapted instruments: the Principals' Leading Functions Questionnaire (PLFQ) and Teachers' Job Performance Questionnaire (TJPQ), which were validated by experts from Bayero University Kano and Sa'adatu Rimi College of Education, Kano. The instruments demonstrated high reliability coefficients of .968 (PLFQ) and .899 (TJPQ). Findings revealed that principals' leading functions including effective communication, motivation, positive interpersonal relationships, and teachers' involvement in decision-making positively influenced teachers' job performance, with an effectiveness level of 89.4% compared to 10.6% ineffectiveness. A significant positive relationship was found between principals' leading functions and teachers' job performance ($r = .751, p < .05$), while no significant difference existed between the leading functions of male and female principals ($t = .251, p > .05$). The study concluded that effective leadership by principals enhances teachers' job performance and

recommended continuous motivation and support for both principals and teachers to improve school effectiveness.

Keywords: Leading functions, principals, teachers' job performance, secondary schools, educational leadership, Nigeria.

Introduction

Principals and teachers are central to the achievement of educational goals, particularly at the secondary school level, which serves as a bridge to higher education. Principals are responsible for performing key managerial functions to ensure school effectiveness and efficiency. Effective leadership is essential because it positively influences the school climate and promotes the attainment of educational objectives (Aliyu & Johnson, 2021).

The principal, working collaboratively with teachers, is expected to create an environment that supports effective teaching and learning. Teachers are valuable assets whose performance depends on proper organization, guidance, motivation, and inspiration (Gemora, 2014). Principals therefore enhance teachers' productivity through effective communication, supervision, motivation, decision-making, teamwork, delegation, discipline management, and professional support (Ukonu & Atukpa, 2025).

This study examined the effectiveness of principals' leading functions and teachers' job performance in senior secondary schools, as well as the level of teachers' contribution to school effectiveness. Leading is a core management function that involves influencing, directing, supervising, motivating, coordinating, communicating, implementing decisions, and evaluating subordinates to achieve organizational goals (Adenaike, Ajayi, Adewale & Odunlami, 2009; Lunenburg & Ornstein, 2008; Gabriel, 2003; Njidda, 2019). Effective leadership also requires managers to build cordial relationships, provide encouragement, and create a conducive work environment that enhances productivity (Ugwu & Okojie, 2016; Wahab & Alfiannor, 2024).

Leadership behaviour determines how managers guide organizational activities toward goal attainment. It includes providing direction, implementing plans, supervising, motivating, training, and supporting employees (Heck & Hallinger, 2010; Mullins & Christy, 2014). Mullins and Christy (2014) identified four major leadership behaviours: directive, supportive, participative, and achievement-oriented leadership. Principals are therefore expected to demonstrate qualities such as honesty, confidence, transparency, commitment, creativity, effective communication, motivation, discipline, delegation, and regular supervision to improve teachers' performance (Adenaike et al., 2009).

Teachers' job performance refers to the effective execution of assigned responsibilities toward achieving classroom and school objectives (Duze, 2012; Aladenusi & Ayodele, 2004). It is influenced by motivation, professional development, supervision, and the availability of teaching resources (Ololube, 2017). School leadership plays a significant role in determining teachers' effectiveness and school success (Puruwita, Jamian & Abdul Aziz, 2021; Azainil, cited in Puruwita et al., 2021).

Research has consistently shown that principals' leadership style affects teachers' job satisfaction, motivation, morale, work climate, and overall performance (Davies & Wilson, 2003; Johnson, 2017; Lazarus, 2014; Adeyemi, 2008). The success or failure of schools largely depends on the ability of principals to coordinate resources, delegate responsibilities, communicate effectively, motivate staff, and create a supportive learning environment (Abdulahi & Kavale, 2016; David, Aunga & Obadia, 2017). Consequently, principals must continuously engage with teachers and other stakeholders through formal and informal interactions to identify challenges, strengthen leadership practices, and improve school performance.

Statement of the problem

Effectiveness of teachers' job performance remains a critical determinant of the quality of education in Nigeria. However, there is growing concern that the teaching profession is increasingly being regarded as a transitional occupation due to factors such as poor remuneration, low societal prestige, and negative public perception. These conditions have contributed to declining teacher morale, reduced commitment, and a tendency among teachers to seek alternative employment opportunities, Abayomi, (2021) in support posited that Nigeria is reaching a period where teaching is fast becoming the last hope for the hopeless, that is a profession for those who have nothing else better to do. As a result, many teachers are unable to devote the required level of dedication necessary for effective teaching and learning.

In senior secondary schools, particularly in the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria, this situation appears more pronounced. Teachers have been observed to exhibit various forms of unprofessional behavior, including absenteeism, truancy, poor record keeping, delay or failure in carrying out assigned responsibilities, inadequate assessment of students' work, and lack of commitment to instructional duties. These practices have negatively impacted the teaching-learning process and overall school effectiveness, thereby raising concerns about the underlying factors influencing teachers' job performance.

School principals, as the chief executives of their institutions, are expected to play a pivotal role in addressing these challenges through the effective application of managerial functions, especially the leading function, which involves motivating staff, maintaining effective communication, fostering positive interpersonal relationships, and creating a supportive work environment that enhances productivity. Through effective leadership, principals are expected to inspire and motivate teachers, promote collaboration, and ensure the successful implementation of educational objectives.

However, it appears that some principals may lack the requisite leadership competencies needed to effectively perform these functions. Challenges such as poor communication, inadequate motivation, weak interpersonal relationships, and limited professional support for teachers may hinder effective leadership practices. In addition, issues such as teacher resistance, lack of cooperation, and insufficient institutional support further complicate the leadership process, thereby affecting its impact on teachers' job performance.

Despite the recognized importance of leadership in improving school outcomes, existing studies have largely focused on general management practices, with limited attention given specifically to the influence of principals' leading function on teachers' job performance, particularly within the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria. This gap in empirical evidence limits the development of targeted strategies for enhancing leadership effectiveness and improving teacher productivity. It is therefore imperative to investigate how principals' leading functions and teachers' job performance in this context. Consequently, this study seeks to examine the influence of leading function of principals on teachers' job performance in senior secondary schools of North-West

Objective of the Study

The objectives of this research work are to:

1. examine the proportion of effectiveness and that of ineffectiveness of principals' leading function in senior secondary schools of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria.
2. determine the relationship between principals' leading function and teacher job performance in senior secondary schools' administration of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria.
3. examine the difference in mean score of leading functions between male and female principals in senior secondary schools' administration of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria.

Research Questions

The study provided an answer to the following question;

1. What is the proportion of effectiveness and that of ineffectiveness of principals' leading function in senior secondary schools of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria?

Research Hypotheses

In view of the study objectives, the following hypotheses were tested at 0.05 level of significance;

1. There is no significant relationship between principals' leading function and teachers' job performance in senior secondary school administration of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria.
2. There is no significant difference in mean score of leading functions between male and female principals in senior secondary schools' administration of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria.

Methodology

The study adopted a correlational survey research design to examine principals' managerial functions and teachers' job performance in public senior secondary schools in North-West, Geo political zone, Nigeria. The target population comprised 1,228 principals and 18,890 teachers from Jigawa, Kano, and Katsina States, which were purposively selected from the seven states in the zone. A sample of 293 principals and teachers was selected using multistage sampling,

involving purposive, convenience, proportionate, and simple random sampling techniques. Data were collected using two validated and pilot-tested instruments: the Principals' Leading Function Questionnaire (PLFQ) and the Teacher Job Performance Questionnaire (TJPQ). Data analysis employed descriptive statistics (frequency counts and percentages) to answer the research questions, while Pearson Product Moment Correlation (PPMC) and the independent samples t-test were used to test the hypotheses. Due to a 4% non-response rate, 282 completed questionnaires were returned and analyzed. The findings were summarized using frequency distributions and class intervals.

Results

The data were analyzed according to the research questions and hypotheses. Research question 1 was answered by descriptive statistics in form frequency counts and percentages and hypotheses 1 was tested using PPMC while hypothesis 2 was tested by t-test for independent sample respectively. All the hypotheses were tested at a 0.05 level of significance.

Research Question 1: What is the proportion of the level of effective and ineffective principals' leading function in senior secondary schools of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria?

Table 1: *Levels of Principals' Leading Functions*

Level of Function	Frequency	Percentage	Cumulative Percentage
Effective	252	89.4	89.4
Ineffective	30	10.6	100
Total	282	100.0	

Source: Field Survey, 2022

The descriptive analysis showed that **89.4%** of principals demonstrated effective leading functions, while **10.6%** were ineffective. This indicates a high level of leadership effectiveness among principals in senior secondary schools in the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria, reflected in their ability to guide and motivate teachers, build a shared vision, provide individual support, promote intellectual stimulation, ensure policy compliance, and foster confidence and goal achievement.

H₀₁: There is no significant relationship between principals' leading function and teachers' job performance in senior secondary school administration of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria.

Table 2: *Correlation between Principals' Leading Function and Teachers' Job Performance*

		Principals' Leading Function Teachers' Job Performance	
Principals' Function	Leading Function	Correlation	Sig. (2-tailed)
		1	.751**
			.000

Teachers' Performance	Job	N	282	282
		Correlation	.751**	1
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.000	
		N	282	282

Source: Field Survey, 2022

A Pearson Product Moment Correlation analysis revealed a strong, positive, and statistically significant relationship between principals' leading functions and teachers' job performance in senior secondary schools in the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria ($r = .751, p = .000 < .05$). Therefore, the null hypothesis was rejected, indicating that effective principals' leading functions are significantly associated with improved teachers' job performance.

H₀₂: There is no significant difference in mean score of leading functions between male and female principals in senior secondary schools' administration of North West Geo-Political Zone, Nigeria.

Table 3: Result of *t*-test for Mean Scores of Leading Functions between Male and Female Principals

Gender	N	Mean	S.D	Std. Error	t-value	Df	P value	Remarks
				Mean				
Male	192	21.88	3.270	.236				
Female	90	21.78	3.023	.319	.251	280	.802	Not sig.
Total	282							

Source: Field Survey, 2022

An independent samples *t*-test was conducted to determine whether there was a difference in the leading functions of male and female principals in senior secondary schools in the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria. The results showed that male principals ($M = 21.88$) and female principals ($M = 21.78$) had similar mean scores. The analysis revealed no significant difference between the two groups ($t = .251, p = .802, p > .05$). Therefore, the null hypothesis was retained, indicating that principals' leading functions do not differ significantly by gender.

Discussion of findings

The findings revealed that principals in the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria demonstrated a high level of effectiveness in performing their leading functions, indicating that they possess essential leadership qualities such as influence, motivation, guidance, assertiveness, cooperation, and effective communication. These attributes contribute to improved teacher performance and align with management theory, which emphasizes that managers should direct, guide, influence, and motivate employees to achieve organizational goals. Effective school leadership also requires principals to be diplomatic, mature, and patient in coordinating staff toward organizational objectives. This finding is consistent with the leadership continuum developed by Rensis in Darr (n.d.), which emphasizes that leadership effectiveness ranges from autocratic to participative approaches, and with Mullins and Christy (2014), who identified directive, supportive, participative, and achievement-oriented leadership as key leadership

behaviours. Although principals are generally expected to possess adequate leadership experience, challenges associated with teachers' commitment and professionalism may affect the full realization of leadership effectiveness.

The study further established a significant relationship between principals' leading functions and teachers' job performance in senior secondary schools in the North-West Geo-Political Zone of Nigeria. This suggests that effective leadership practices, including motivation, guidance, communication, appraisal, and positive interpersonal relationships, enhance teachers' productivity and commitment. This finding corroborates the studies of Virina (2019), who reported that school leadership and management competencies directly influence teachers' job performance; Adejumobi and Ojikutu (2013), who found that principals' leadership techniques significantly affect teachers' performance; and Mwanza, Muya and Mwanza (2019), who established a positive and significant relationship between principals' leadership techniques and teachers' productivity. Effective leaders also promote staff development by listening to teachers, recognizing good performance, and encouraging continuous professional growth.

The findings also revealed no significant difference between the leading functions of male and female principals, indicating that leadership effectiveness is determined by competence rather than gender. This contradicts earlier studies and stereotypes suggesting that male principals are more effective in school leadership, particularly in discipline and conflict management (Kingsley, Mbonu & Ikedimma, 2021), and the perception that women are less competent leaders (Foschi, 1996). Instead, the findings support Olayinka and Warren (2019), who reported that women are equally capable of providing effective school leadership. The results therefore reinforce the importance of merit-based leadership appointments and promote gender equality in educational administration.

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